

cream-colored
neck patch



Japanese marten

Martes melampus

Although they belong to the weasel family, whose members are known for catching small mammals, Japanese martens are opportunists when it comes to food, adapting their diets to the seasons and whatever is available where they live. In spring, for example, birds may feature as prey of some populations, while insects make up a large part of their diet in summer.

Dispersal agents

Martens do eat small mammals such as field mice, as well as birds, eggs, fish, frogs, and crustaceans. However, their droppings, or scat, contain a wider variety of whole plant and fruit seeds than other native flesh-eating mammals, making the martens vital seed dispersers, particularly for plants producing flesh-rich fruits.

Japanese martens were once bred for their fur, which varies from yellowish to dark brown among the three subspecies, but very little is known about these agile and elusive mammals in the wild. They regularly mark their boundaries with scat, are thought to be highly territorial, and prefer broadleaf woodland to conifers due to the wider array of food choices the former offers.

Males are larger than females, which bear one to five kits per litter. Other than females with kits, Japanese martens live and hunt alone. They are threatened by the rise in the number of conifer plantations, increased use of agrochemicals, and overhunting for the fur trade.

In Japanese folklore, martens are said to have shapeshifting abilities

↔ 19–22 in (48–55 cm)
⚖ 2–3 lb (1–1.5 kg)
⊗ Locally common
🐾 Mammals, birds, plants
🏠



face has black "mask"
like a raccoon



Raccoon dog

Nyctereutes procyonoides

Native to East Asia, the raccoon dog is so adaptable that it is now widespread in eastern and northern Europe, where it was initially introduced by the fur trade. This member of the canid (dog) family is a distant cousin of wolves and dogs, but several characteristics set it apart. It is the only canid to semihibernate in winter, going into a state of lethargy unless its fat reserves are too low. It does not bark, but whines, mews, or growls. Raccoon dogs have smaller teeth and longer intestines than other canids—traits found in animals that consume plant matter. During fall in their native range, fruit and berries make up a large part of their diet.

long winter
coat with
thick fur
undercoat

↔ 20–28 in (50–71 cm)
⚖ 7–28 lb (3–12.7 kg)
⊗ Common
🐾 Birds, rodents, frogs, fruit
🏠



◁ READY FOR WINTER

Due to their relatively poor eyesight, raccoon dogs rely on their sense of smell to find enough food in fall to fatten up for winter.